

often put his selection in jeopardy.

On the other hand, two new names, Irfan Yadwad and Parthib Gogoi, have turned heads in the league this season.

Irfan had scored 36 goals in 34 games for I-League 2 side, Bengaluru United, before moving to Chennaiyin last summer.

Despite getting limited game time this season, he had his moment in the sun when he scored the winner against defending champion Mohun Bagan on March 31.

"He's a young Indian No. 9 who has got a lot to learn. He scored in the Super Cup. He's had five or six chances before in the Indian Super League to score. So to get his goal (winner) and what it meant and the quality showed, that will stand him in good stead," Coyle said.

Gogoi, on the other hand, has nine goals and an assist in all competitions this season for NorthEast United FC (NEUFC).

"We're lucky to have him. And he needs to grow slowly. He needs a lot of experience. He needs to work more.

"Yes, he scores, but he needs to participate more in the game," Juan Pedro Benali, the head coach of NEUFC, said about Gogoi.

Irfan is 22. Parthib, a year younger. Neither has played under Stimac in the senior team yet. Their proper grooming and opportunities would only help the Blue Tigers.



Beyond the gamut of ISL

Though ISL houses the best senior talents in the country, there are youngsters in the I-League — the second division of Indian football — who have impressed with their attacking prowess.

Aizawl's 23-year-old striker, Lalrinzuala Lalbiaknia, recently scored 15 goals in 20 matches, breaking a decade-old joint record of Chhetri and Rafi of most goals by an Indian in an I-League season.

David Lalhlansanga, 22, has been

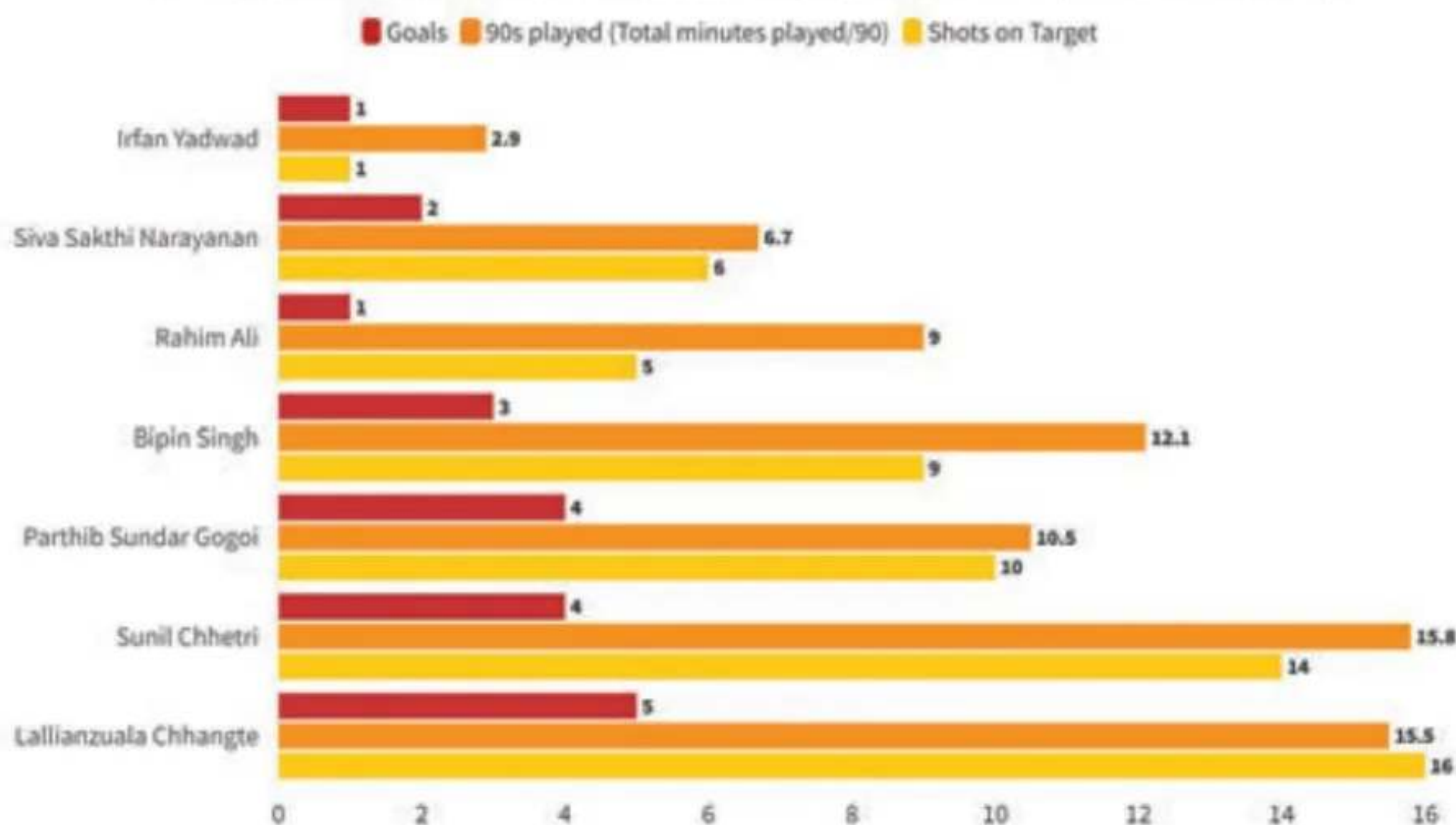
another sensation, scoring 11 goals and assisting three more (in all competitions) for Mohammedan Sporting, eventually helping his side win its maiden I-League title and secure ISL promotion.

For Stimac (**seen with Chhangte above**), these will be probable avenues to explore.

Just like the discovery of diamonds in South Africa, a rightful heir to Chhetri might just be found in the most unpredictable of places, like a transparent rock on a river bed.

(All data recorded till April 2, 2024)

Indian goalscorers in ISL 2023-24 who are conventional forwards



Source: FBREF, Opta • All data in the article is till the ISL match Odisha FC vs Punjab FC on April 2, 2024